He knew when it was time to be serious too. We worked really hard in training but you never noticed it with Kiddo because he made sure every session was different: it stopped us ever getting bored and the new routines kept players fresh. Scholesy and Nicky Butt and the Nevilles had known Brian even longer than I had: he was United through and through. I think that's part of the reason he handled relationships between people at the club so well. I know I'm not the only one who, at some point during his time at Old Trafford, had to thank him for defusing a confrontation with the boss. He never went against the manager, or tried to undermine him in any way, but I always felt like he looked out for us players. It made for a really happy dressing room.

It was also a pretty successful dressing room. We were disappointed to miss out in Europe but, in May 1997, winning the Premiership for the second year running was a big achievement in itself. In the end, we finished seven points clear, but it was more than just a one-or two-horse race. Liverpool, Newcastle and Arsenal all had a go at different times in the season. We won the title with a couple of weeks to spare; it was a bit strange becoming champions thanks to another team losing. On Monday night we drew 3–3 with Middlesbrough at Old Trafford. You don't forget any game where Gary Neville scores a goal. Then on Tuesday, Liverpool, the only team who could beat us to the title, had a televised match against Wimbledon. I was round at Ben Thornley's house with Gary to see it. I don't like watching soccer on television in the best of times and, with what was at stake, I couldn't stand the tension. Gary and I ended up going out for a walk and missing the whole of the second half.

By the time we got back, Wimbledon had won and that meant we were champions. Normally at the end of a game in which you win a trophy, you can let some of the adrenaline out, on the field and back in the dressing room. That evening in 1997, though, we were sitting in Ben Thornley's lounge. We broke the club curfew that night; the only time I ever did. We had a game against Newcastle coming up on Thursday and so we should have been at home, getting an early night. I'm not a drinker or a clubber anyway, as a general rule. But that evening was different. We'd won the League, hadn't we? It didn't feel like an occasion to be sitting indoors, so the three of us went out on the town in Manchester and had a beer or two more than we should have done. I'm sure the manager knew—he knows everything about everybody—but we got away with it. And there was no harm done because we drew against Newcastle two evenings later.

I think the really big winner that season was probably my cell phone